

plants.

- B. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they produced less jasmonic acid than salicylic acid, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced about the same amount of jasmonic acid and salicylic acid.
- C. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced both jasmonic acid and salicylic acid, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they exclusively produced salicylic acid.
- D. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they produced less jasmonic acid than did control plants, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced more jasmonic acid and salicylic acid than did control plants.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it best describes data from the graph that support the researchers' conclusion about whitefly-induced defenses in tomato plants. According to the text, tomato plants produce airborne chemicals that prompt nearby tomato plants to increase their production of appropriate defensive chemicals, such as jasmonic acid in response to herbivory and salicylic acid in response to microbial infection. The text goes on to indicate that researchers concluded that whiteflies induce tomato plants to emit chemicals that cause nearby plants to defend against microbial infection instead of herbivory from whiteflies. The graph shows that control tomato plants (plants that weren't exposed to any chemicals from nearby tomato plants and weren't subsequently infested with whiteflies) produced about 140 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight and about 120 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight, which indicates the baseline levels of these defensive chemicals in tomato plants. The graph also shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants produced about 205 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight when subsequently infested by whiteflies, which is more than the amount produced by the control plants. This suggests that when infested with whiteflies, tomato plants that weren't previously exposed to air from nearby whitefly-infested plants begin producing higher levels of jasmonic acid to defend against the infestation. Finally, the graph also shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants and then subsequently infested by whiteflies produced approximately 100 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight (which is less than control plants did) and approximately 175 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight (which is more than control plants did). This suggests that whiteflies cause tomato plants to emit chemical signals that decrease nearby plants' defenses against whitefly herbivory relative to baseline levels and redirect their defenses toward microbial infection, thereby supporting the researchers' conclusion that whiteflies cause tomato plants to emit airborne chemical signals that induce nearby plants to preferentially defend against microbes even when experiencing herbivory from whiteflies.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the graph shows that tomato plants exposed to whitefly-infested plants produced less jasmonic acid than salicylic acid (about 100 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight vs. about 175 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight), and although this might suggest that those plants are therefore better defended against microbial attack than against herbivory, this wouldn't be sufficient to conclude that this is the case: without reference to the relative levels of defensive chemicals produced by the plants in the other experimental conditions, it would be impossible to conclude that exposure to air from whitefly-infested plants either induces or diminishes these plants' defenses to different kinds of threats. Furthermore, the graph shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants produced about 205 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight and about 130 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight, not that they produced the same amount of the two acids. Choice C is incorrect because it inaccurately describes the data in the graph. The graph shows that plants in all three conditions produced both jasmonic and salicylic acid, not that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants produce no jasmonic acid at all. Choice D is incorrect. Although the graph shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants produced about 100 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight when infested, which is less than the amount produced by control plants (about 140 nanograms per gram of dry weight), and although the graph shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants produced about 205 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight when infested (which is more than the amount produced by control plants) and about 130 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight (which is more than the approximately 120 nanograms per gram of dry weight produced by control plants), this wouldn't support the researchers' conclusion that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants preferentially defend against microbial infection—that is, that they increase their levels of salicylic acid and decrease their levels of jasmonic acid relative to control plants. Rather, the data would suggest that exposure to air from whitefly-infested plants reduces plants' defenses against herbivory, but these data wouldn't indicate that whiteflies induce plants to redirect their defenses to guard against microbial infection. Furthermore, the data concerning plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants merely indicate that these plants increase their defenses against both herbivory and microbial infection when infested by whiteflies.